

GovCon BD Upskilling Program

Opportunity Discovery

Module 2.1 | Domain D2 (20%)

DURATION

2-3 hours

FORMAT

Live Instructor-Led

GovConGiants

30-Day Foundation Program

Module 2.1: Opportunity Discovery

Learning Objectives

By the end of this module, learners will be able to:

1. **Navigate** SAM.gov to search for contract opportunities
2. **Distinguish** between opportunity types (RFP, RFQ, RFI, Sources Sought)
3. **Apply** qualification criteria to assess opportunity fit
4. **Set up** saved searches for ongoing opportunity monitoring
5. **Document** opportunities in a structured log for team review

Required Reading/Viewing

Official Government Resources (Free)

1. **SAM.gov** - Contract Opportunities
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/opportunities>
 - Focus: Searching and filtering opportunities
2. **SAM.gov Help** - “How to Search Contract Opportunities”
 - URL: <https://sam.gov/content/help>
 - Focus: Search functions and saved searches

Action Plan Journal References

- **Upcoming Project List**: pages 48-52
- **Monitor Sources Sought and Respond**: pages 132-133
- **Identify IDV Opportunities**: page 134

Lesson Content

1. Introduction to SAM.gov Opportunities

SAM.gov is the official government website for finding federal contract opportunities. All opportunities over \$25,000 must be posted here.

What You'll Find:

- Active solicitations (RFPs, RFQs)
- Pre-solicitation notices
- Sources Sought / RFI
- Award notices
- Justifications for sole source

Why This Matters for Your Role

Even if you're not in BD, knowing how to find and recognize opportunities helps you spot relevant opportunities in your area of expertise, understand what your company is pursuing, and contribute to qualification discussions.

2. Types of Opportunities

Understanding the different opportunity types helps you know what action is needed:

RFP	Request for Proposal	Formal solicitation requiring full proposal	Submit proposal by deadline
RFQ	Request for Quotation	Request for pricing on defined requirements	Submit quote
RFI	Request for Information	Market research - agency gathering info	Respond to influence requirements
Sources Sought	Sources Sought Notice	Agency looking for capable vendors	Respond to get on their radar
Pre-Sol	Pre-Solicitation Notice	Heads up that RFP/ RFQ is coming	Prepare, watch for solicitation
Award	Award Notice	Contract has been awarded	Research winner, learn from loss

3. Navigating SAM.gov**Accessing Contract Opportunities:**

1. Go to <https://sam.gov>

2. Click “Contract Opportunities” in the main menu
3. Use the search bar and filters

Key Search Filters:

Keyword	Search title and description	“IT support services”
Notice Type	Filter by opportunity type	“Solicitation”
NAICS Code	Filter by industry	“541512”
PSC Code	Filter by product/service	“D302”
Set-Aside	Filter by small business type	“8(a)”, “SDVOSB”
Place of Performance	Filter by location	“Virginia”
Agency	Filter by contracting agency	“Department of Defense”
Posted Date	Filter by when posted	“Last 30 days”
Response Date	Filter by deadline	“Active only”

4. Reading an Opportunity Notice

Key Information to Extract:

Title	Brief description of requirement
Solicitation Number	Unique identifier for tracking
Notice Type	RFP, RFQ, Sources Sought, etc.
Posted Date	When it was published
Response Date	Deadline for submission
Set-Aside	Small business restriction (if any)
NAICS Code	Industry classification
Place of Performance	Where work will be done
Contracting Office	Who is buying
Point of Contact	Who to ask questions

Description	Scope of work summary
Attachments	Full solicitation documents

5. Opportunity Qualification

Not every opportunity is worth pursuing. Use these criteria to qualify:

Basic Qualification Questions:

Do we do this work?	Core capability match
Can we meet the set-aside?	Eligibility requirement
Do we have relevant past performance?	Evaluation factor
Is the timeline realistic?	Can we respond in time?
Is the contract size right for us?	Resource availability
Do we have/want a presence in this location?	Place of performance
Do we know this customer?	Relationship advantage

Quick Qualification Matrix:

Capability	Direct match	Adjacent capability	No experience
Set-Aside	We qualify	Need partner	Don't qualify
Past Performance	3+ relevant	1-2 relevant	None
Timeline	30+ days	15-30 days	Under 15 days
Customer	Known	Some contact	No relationship

6. Setting Up Saved Searches

Why Save Searches:

- Get email notifications for new opportunities
- Don't miss relevant postings
- Save time on daily searching

How to Create a Saved Search:

1. Build your search using filters
2. Click “Save Search”
3. Name your search (e.g., “VA IT Services”)
4. Set notification frequency (daily recommended)
5. Confirm email settings

Recommended Saved Searches:

- By target agency + your NAICS codes
- By set-aside type you qualify for
- By keywords specific to your services
- By geographic region

7. Beyond SAM.gov: Other Sources

While SAM.gov is primary, other sources can provide early intelligence:

Acquisition Gateway Forecast	Upcoming opportunities	acquisitiongateway.gov/forecast
Agency OSDBU	Small business opportunities	Agency websites
Agency Procurement Sites	Agency-specific postings	Varies

Free Sources to Monitor

- Agency forecast pages (search “[Agency] procurement forecast”)
- Agency OSDBU event calendars
- Industry day announcements in SAM.gov

AI Accelerator: Using AI for Opportunity Discovery

AI tools can help you quickly analyze opportunities, understand requirements, and make qualification decisions.

Prompt 1: Summarize a SAM.gov Opportunity

Use When: You find an opportunity and need a quick summary for your team.

I found this opportunity on SAM.gov. Please summarize it for a quick internal review:

[PASTE THE OPPORTUNITY DESCRIPTION FROM SAM.GOV]

Provide:

1. A 2-3 sentence executive summary
2. Key requirements (bullets)
3. Important dates and deadlines
4. Set-aside type and eligibility requirements
5. Initial qualification assessment (what do we need to be competitive?)

Prompt 2: Analyze RFI or Sources Sought

Use When: You need to decide whether to respond to market research.

This Sources Sought notice was posted on SAM.gov:

[PASTE THE SOURCES SOUGHT OR RFI TEXT]

Help me understand:

1. What is the government trying to learn?
2. What information should we include in our response?
3. How can we use this response to influence the eventual RFP?
4. What questions should we ask the contracting officer?
5. Should we respond? What's the strategic value?

Prompt 3: Opportunity Qualification Assessment

Use When: You need to quickly assess fit for an opportunity.

We found this opportunity and need to decide if it's worth pursuing:

Opportunity: [TITLE]

Agency: [AGENCY]

NAICS: [CODE]

Set-Aside: [TYPE]

Estimated Value: [AMOUNT]
Response Deadline: [DATE]
Requirements Summary: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION]

Our company:

- Capabilities: [YOUR SERVICES]
- Certifications: [YOUR CERTS]
- Past Performance: [RELEVANT EXPERIENCE]
- Customer Relationships: [ANY EXISTING RELATIONSHIPS]

Assess this opportunity against typical go/no-go criteria:

1. Capability match (Green/Yellow/Red)
2. Set-aside eligibility (Green/Yellow/Red)
3. Past performance relevance (Green/Yellow/Red)
4. Timeline feasibility (Green/Yellow/Red)
5. Competitive position (Green/Yellow/Red)

Provide an overall recommendation and key considerations.

Pro Tips for AI-Assisted Opportunity Discovery

Paste full opportunity text for accurate analysis	Ask AI to find opportunities (use SAM.gov)
Use AI to summarize long solicitations quickly	Let AI make final go/no-go decisions
Get AI help prioritizing your pipeline	Skip reading the actual RFP
Draft qualification memos with AI assistance	Rely on AI for deadline calculations

Remember

SAM.gov is your source of truth. AI helps you analyze faster, but always verify details against the official posting.

I Applied Exercise: Build Your Opportunity Log

Scenario: Your manager asks you to identify 10 potential opportunities that might be relevant to your company's capabilities.

Part 1: Define Your Search Criteria

Before searching, identify:

- 2-3 NAICS codes relevant to your company
- Target agencies (or use "all")
- Set-aside types your company qualifies for
- Geographic focus (if any)

Part 2: Search SAM.gov

1. Go to <https://sam.gov/content/opportunities>
2. Apply your filters
3. Review the results
4. Identify 10 opportunities that might be relevant

Part 3: Document Each Opportunity

For each of the 10 opportunities, record:

- Solicitation number
- Title
- Agency
- Notice type
- Response deadline
- Set-aside type
- Estimated value (if listed)
- Quick qualification assessment

Part 4: Create a Saved Search

1. Build a search for your target market
2. Save it with notifications enabled
3. Note the search name in your log

Time: 45-60 minutes

Work Artifact: Opportunity Log

Log Header

Your Name: _____

Date: _____

Search Criteria Used: _____

Opportunity Entry Template

Solicitation #	
Title	
Agency	
Notice Type	
Response Date	
Set-Aside	
Est. Value	
NAICS Code	
Qualification	Green / Yellow / Red
Notes	

(Copy this template for all 10 opportunities)

Saved Search Created

Search Name	
Filters Used	
Notification Frequency	

Summary

Total opportunities reviewed	
Green (likely pursue)	
Yellow (needs discussion)	
Red (not a fit)	

Knowledge Check (Self-Assessment)

Question 1 (Recall)

What is the difference between an RFP and an RFI?

- A) RFP is for products, RFI is for services
- B) **RFP is a formal solicitation requiring a proposal; RFI is market research gathering information**
- C) RFP is only for large contracts, RFI is for small purchases
- D) There is no difference

Correct Answer: B

Question 2 (Application)

You find an opportunity that matches your capabilities, but it's set aside for 8(a) companies and your company doesn't have that certification. What should you do?

- A) Submit a proposal anyway
- B) Ignore the opportunity
- C) **Consider teaming with an 8(a) company as a subcontractor**
- D) Request the set-aside be removed

Correct Answer: C

Question 3 (Scenario)

You see a "Sources Sought" notice for services your company provides. The notice asks for capability statements. What is the government trying to accomplish?

- A) They're awarding a contract to whoever responds
- B) **They're gathering market information to plan a future procurement**
- C) They're required to post this but won't read responses
- D) They've already selected a winner

Correct Answer: B

Question 4 (Application)

An opportunity has a response deadline of 5 days from now. Your company has never worked with this agency and has no proposal draft. What's the likely qualification?

- A) Green - submit anyway
- B) Yellow - possible with overtime
- C) **Red - not enough time to submit quality response**
- D) Green - short deadlines mean less competition

Correct Answer: C

Question 5 (Recall)

Where do you find the detailed requirements and submission instructions for an RFP?

- A) In the notice title
- B) **In the attachments section of the opportunity**
- C) By calling the contracting officer
- D) On the agency's main website

Correct Answer: B

Manager Discussion Prompts

1. **Current Context:** "What NAICS codes and agencies should I focus on when searching for opportunities? Are there specific contracts we're tracking?"
2. **Application:** "How does our company currently track opportunities? Is there a pipeline or CRM I should be aware of?"
3. **Career Development:** "How can I contribute to opportunity identification beyond this exercise?"

Completion Criteria

To complete this module:

- ☐ Read all required materials (approximately 20 minutes)
- ☐ Complete the lesson content review (30-45 minutes)
- ☐ Finish the Applied Exercise on SAM.gov
- ☐ Submit an Opportunity Log with 10 documented opportunities
- ☐ Create at least one saved search with notifications
- ☐ Review the Knowledge Check questions (self-assessment)
- ☐ Participate in manager discussion (or document self-reflection)

Estimated Total Time: 2-3 hours

Additional Resources

Key Terms

Solicitation: Formal request for proposals or quotes

Sources Sought: Market research notice seeking capability information

Set-Aside: Contract reserved for specific business categories

NAICS Code: Industry classification code

Response Date: Deadline for submitting proposals

Pre-Solicitation: Advance notice that a solicitation is coming

Action Plan Journal Activities

After completing this module, use your **Action Plan Journal** to:

1. Complete the **Upcoming Project List** (pages 48-52) based on SAM.gov searches
2. Review **Monitor Sources Sought and Respond** (pages 132-133) for responding strategies
3. Track opportunities using the **Identify IDV Opportunities** template (page 134)

Journal Reference

The Opportunity Log you completed aligns with the Upcoming Project List in your Action Plan Journal. Transfer your findings to maintain a single tracking system.